General rule – light, vision and darkness · "Playing the Game" chapter of SRD 5.2.1

What you can see depends on **light** and **obscurement**. An area is in **bright light**, **dim light** (Lightly Obscured) or **darkness** (Heavily Obscured). Normal vision sees well only in bright light.

In a **Lightly Obscured** area you have **Disadvantage** on Wisdom (Perception) checks that rely on sight. In a **Heavily Obscured** area you are **effectively Blinded** regarding what is there.

🎲 Quick summary:

1. **Bright light**: you see normally.
2. **Dim light**: Lightly Obscured, Disadvantage on sight Perception.
3. **Darkness**: Heavily Obscured, as if Blinded.
4. Darkvision, Blindsight, Truesight: see the table.

⚠ Change from 2014

SRD 2024 keeps the three light levels with the same effects and clarifies Truesight and Tremorsense.

⚠ Flaw in the rule and fixes Table rule

The SRD doesn't give a range for every light source. Fix: set the light range before play.

💡 Narrative option: Table rule

The DM can describe the light quality (flickering torch, moonlight) so the threshold is clear.

Step 1 – Determine the light:

Bright light, dim light or darkness according to the area's sources.

Step 2 – Check vision:

Normal vision suffices in bright light. Darkvision: dim becomes bright, darkness becomes dim.

Step 3 – Apply obscurement:

Lightly Obscured: Disadvantage on sight Perception. Heavily Obscured: Blinded for that area.

Step 4 – Other senses:

Blindsight, Tremorsense or Truesight replace sight.

Step 5 – Light sources:

A torch gives 20 ft of bright light and 20 ft more of dim light.

Example: Brann has Darkvision (60 ft). In an unlit corridor 40 ft away, he sees in grayscale as in dim light: Disadvantage on Perception.

Sense / area	Effect
Bright light	Normal vision.
Dim light	Lightly Obscured: Disadvantage on sight Perception checks.
Darkness	Heavily Obscured: effectively Blinded.
Darkvision	Within range: dim → bright, darkness → dim (grayscale).
Blindsight	Perceives surroundings without sight within range.
Truesight	Sees in darkness, invisible creatures and illusions within range.
Tremorsense	Detects nearby creatures through vibrations.

⚠ Common questions:

What is dim light?

Weak light: a Lightly Obscured area.

Does Darkvision show colors?

No, only shades of gray.

How far does a torch light?

About 20 ft of bright light and 20 ft more of dim light.

Can I hide in dim light?

Yes: cover or a Heavily Obscured area is needed to Hide.

Can I see in magical darkness?

Only with Truesight.

Blindsight and invisible creatures?

Yes: it perceives without sight within its range.

Thick fog?

Heavily Obscured: as if Blinded.

⚠ Debate points and table options: Table rule

Dim light and Hide

Hide in dim light without cover? **Option**: only in Heavily Obscured areas.

Magical light

Does magical light dispel magical darkness? **Option**: by spell level.

Partial vision

Seeing part of an area. **Option**: Disadvantage only for the obscured part.

Mixed sources

Several light sources: **Option**: take the strongest.

⚠ Rule clarifications (answers found on the web, reworded):

Darkvision

It doesn't distinguish colors, only shades of gray.

Obscurement

Light = Disadvantage on sight Perception; heavy = as if Blinded.

Magical light

The Light spell gives bright light for 20 ft and dim light for 20 ft more.

Hide

You need cover or a Heavily Obscured area.

These points remain open to discussion: your feedback is welcome to refine this sheet.

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